

The Ten Bridesmaids



SCRIPTURE · Matthew 25:1–13

The Ten Bridesmaids · ESV

MAIN MESSAGE

The parable of the ten bridesmaids teaches that readiness for Jesus's return is not something we can improvise at the last moment, but something formed over time through a genuine, persevering relationship with Him. We are wise to live with consistent, sustained spiritual readiness—living faithfully, staying awake to our calling, and cultivating intimacy with Jesus—in anticipation of His return. Though the bridegroom may delay longer than expected, this parable issues a merciful warning to never settle for just outward religious activity while our hearts remain far from God. When Jesus returns and the door finally closes, only those who have become ready will enter.

DISCOVERY QUESTIONS

- 01** Do you feel spiritually ready right now, or are you assuming you are? Why?
- 02** Where in your life are you delaying what you know matters most with God?
- 03** How does delay show up in your spiritual life right now?

Discovering Truth

Jesus tells this parable while teaching about His return, knowing there will be a delay. Life will feel normal, and urgency will fade, causing most men to assume they have time. This is where men drift—not necessarily through outright rejection but through neglect and delay. This parable confronts the assumption that readiness can be addressed later, showing that what is built over time ultimately matters.

01 · PARABLE

The Bridegroom

The bridegroom represents Jesus, who will return and reveal what is real. His delay is not accidental—Jesus' delay gives men an opportunity to repent and come to him, and how a man responds in the delay of Christ exposes what a man has built his life upon. When Jesus arrives, the question is not what a man claims, but whether he has an authentic relationship with Jesus.

02 · PARABLE

The Wise Bridesmaids

The wise bridesmaids are prepared. They bring oil, representing the Holy Spirit and a genuine, dependent, loving relationship with Jesus built over time—consistent, personal investment in their relationship with God. Their readiness is not rushed or reactive; it is the result of steady faithfulness. They have something real beneath the surface that sustains them when the moment comes.

03 · PARABLE

The Foolish Bridesmaids

The foolish bridesmaids are unprepared. They assume what they have is enough, but that assumption exposes the gap. They are in the right place and look the part, but they lack what matters. Their problem is not ignorance—it is presumption. When the moment comes, they realize too late that an authentic relationship with Jesus cannot be rushed or borrowed.

Jesus makes it clear that the dividing line is relationship. Through Him, men are invited into a real, ongoing relationship with God—not surface-level belief, but being known by Him. The warning is direct: there will be a moment when preparation is no longer possible. The door will close, and what has been built will be revealed. The Gospel is not just an invitation to believe—it is an invitation to walk with God over time. The question is whether a man will respond now or assume he has more time.

Key Points

01

Lack of spiritual readiness doesn't happen through rejection—it happens through neglect, assuming you have more time to get serious.

02

What sustains you in the moment is the power and presence of the Spirit and a genuine relationship with God that is cultivated and built over time; readiness cannot be rushed or borrowed.

03

The dividing line is not appearance or proximity, but whether you have a real relationship with Jesus before the door closes.

GROUP DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

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| 01 Do you relate to Jesus more as someone you know about or someone you truly know? | 04 What are you assuming will be there later that you are not building now? |
| 02 What are you consistently building into your relationship with God right now? | 05 If Jesus returned today, would you feel spiritually prepared? |
| 03 Where do you see evidence of real spiritual depth in your life? | 06 What needs to change in your life so you are not just assuming you are ready? |

Personal Reflection

Most men prepare hard for what they care about. You train, study, and show up ready when it counts. But spiritually, many men drift. You assume you'll get serious later, when life slows down or something forces you to. That's the mistake. The foolish bridesmaids didn't reject the bridegroom—they just weren't ready. Proximity wasn't enough. Knowing about Jesus wasn't enough. You don't build a real relationship with Him in a moment of urgency. You build it over time—consistently, intentionally, quietly. You don't rise to the moment—rather, the moment (of Jesus' return) reveals what you have built.

PERSONAL REFLECTION QUESTIONS

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| 01 What does your current spiritual life look like right now? | 04 What distractions are pulling your attention away from what matters most? |
| 02 Where are you assuming you'll "get serious later" instead of now? | 05 What is one clear step you will take this week to build real spiritual readiness? |
| 03 What is one daily habit you need to build to strengthen your relationship with God? | |